

BULLYING PREVENTION AND EDUCATION

Loudoun County Public Schools is committed to a school environment that is free from bullying and cyberbullying.

A. Definitions.

1. Bullying is the systematic and chronic inflicting of physical hurt or psychological distress on another person. The Code of Virginia § [22.1-276.01](#) defines bullying as “any aggressive and unwanted behavior that is intended to harm, intimidate, or humiliate the victim; involves a real or perceived power imbalance between the aggressor or aggressors and victim; and is repeated over time or causes severe emotional trauma. “Bullying” includes cyberbullying. “Bullying” does not include ordinary teasing, horseplay, arguments or peer conflict.”

2. Cyberbullying means bullying that occurs through the use of technology, including through cell phones and other electronic devices or technology capable of accessing the Internet.

3. The Code of Virginia requires that policies and procedures regarding bullying and cyberbullying do not prohibit expression of religious, philosophical, or political views, unless that expression creates an actual disruption of the work of the school.

B. Bullying Characteristics.

1. Bullying involves physical and emotional behaviors that are intentional, controlling, and hurtful and create a harassing, intimidating, hostile or otherwise offensive environment.

2. Bullying is any unwanted and repeated written, verbal, cyber, or physical behavior, including any threatening, insulting, or dehumanizing gesture, by a student or adult, that is severe or pervasive enough to create feelings of intimidation, alienation, or humiliation.

3. Bullying behavior may be communicated openly and directly, or subtly and indirectly, in person or by other methods of communication, to include technology.

4. Bullying behavior is a subtype of the broader concept of peer aggression and victimization; therefore, bullying prevention approaches must focus broadly on reducing all forms of aggressions and victimization, regardless of the intent, frequency, and power differential.

C. Reporting Bullying Behavior. Any student who believes they have been the target of bullying, or any other person in the school community who observes or receives notice that a student has or may have been the target of bullying, should immediately report incidents to a school administrator or faculty/staff member. When

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allegations of bullying between LCPS students are reported to the principal, or designee, such incidents should be addressed as soon as possible, including by investigating any allegation that could result in disciplinary action in accordance with School Board Policy [8205](#). LCPS will provide protections designed to ensure that any student who is a victim of or a witness to an instance of bullying is not deterred from reporting or seeking support for such instance of bullying by fears of retaliation, social alienation or rejection or other negative treatment.

D. Parent/Guardian Notification. The principal, or administrative designee, shall attempt to promptly report any allegation of bullying, by or against a child, to the parent/guardian via telephone, personal conference, and/or in writing. The status of any investigation of an allegation or incident of bullying, as defined by this policy, shall be reported to the parent/guardian within 24 hours notice. Notification must be consistent with the student privacy rights under the applicable provisions of the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act of 1974 (FERPA). At any time during the investigation, it has been determined that criminal charges may be pursued against the perpetrator, all appropriate local law enforcement agencies should be notified.

E. Prevention and Intervention.

1. Bullying prevention and intervention programming shall include evidenced-based curricula, practices, and strategies. Records are to be kept and collected, and the data analyzed semiannually.

2. A school administrator shall be designated as the bullying prevention coordinator at each school to oversee the implementation of the division-wide program that includes the following:

- a. Annual training for faculty, staff and students on how to prevent and identify bullying, how to report suspected bullying, and how to take developmentally appropriate steps to intervene with bullying;
- b. Steps for receiving, reporting and investigating complaints;
- c. Parent/guardian education
- d. Privacy and confidentiality for all involved individuals; and
- e. Notification of law enforcement when it is suspected a criminal offense may have occurred;

3. This policy shall be prominently displayed on the division's and individual school's websites.

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F. Intervention and Response.

1. Developmentally appropriate interventions with students accused of bullying, as well as those identified as the victims, and resolutions of all complaints are essential to maintaining a safe learning environment.

2. Any student who is a victim of bullying will receive a list of support services and resources available relating to reporting and seeking support after experiencing an instance of bullying, including mental health support services, and any information necessary to access such support services and resources. Such list of supports, which can currently be found on the [LCPS website](#), are hereby incorporated by reference.

3. Bullying violations under this policy are prohibited and constitute grounds for interventions to include but not limited to Restorative Practices and/or student discipline ranging from in-school disciplinary measures to involuntary transfer, short or long-term suspensions and/or expulsion under school board policies. When investigating the allegation and/or incident, all of the surrounding facts, circumstances, severity, and age/developmental factors should be considered.

G. Monitoring. The principal and designated assistant principal(s) are responsible for implementing, enforcing, and monitoring this policy.

[Former Policy 8-41]

Adopted: 6/24/14

Revised: 12/3/19, 11/14/23

Current Revision: 6/23/26

Leg Refs.: Code of Virginia §§ [22.1-208.01](#), [22.1-276.01](#), [22.1-279.6](#), [22.1-291.4](#)

Cross Ref.: Policy [8650](#), Student Technology Acceptable/Responsible Use Policy; Policy [8030](#), Student Discrimination and Harassment; Policy [8035](#), Title IX, Sex-Based Discrimination, Sexual Harassment; Policy [8205](#), Authority to Take Disciplinary and other Action Against Students